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2004-2012

Medal Glut

That breakthrough came in Athens 2004. Devendra Jhajharia hurled the javelin into history with a gold in the F44/46 category, while Rajinder Singh Rahelu took bronze in powerlifting. Eight years later in London, H.N. Girisha's high jump silver reinforced the sense that Indian para-athletes could consistently stand on the podium.



Institutions Take Root

Change was brewing elsewhere. In 1992, M. Mahadeva and his colleagues in Bengaluru founded the Physically Handicapped Sports Federation of India — later renamed the Paralympic Committee of India (PCI). It became the governing body for parasport, though formal government recognition only arrived in 2016. The groundwork was being laid for a breakthrough.

AP



B. VELANKANNI RAJ



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2016-2024

Acceleration

Rio 2016 marked a new dawn. India sent its largest contingent — 19 athletes — and returned with four medals. Jhajharia struck gold again with a world record. Mariyappan Thangavelu soared to high jump glory, while Varun Singh Bhati joined him on the podium with a bronze in the same event. Deepa Malik, with her shot put silver, became the first Indian woman to medal at the Paralympics. Then came the explosion. At Tokyo 2021, 54 athletes delivered 19 medals across athletics, shooting, badminton, archery, and table tennis. Three years later, Paris raised the bar even higher: 84 athletes, 29 medals, seven of them gold. India was no longer an outsider; it was a Paralympic power. Behind the medals lies a different story — of systems finally catching up with athletes' ambition. The Sports Authority of India upgraded facilities, TOPS funding allowed para-athletes to train as full-time professionals, corporate sponsorship began to flow in, and the launch of the Khelo India Para Games in 2023 widened the pipeline..